load and render a template containing the HTML for their page. The `django.shortcuts.render()` function encapsulates most of what you need to render some HTML in a single call. Figure 3.2 shows the code savings you get by using the shortcut.

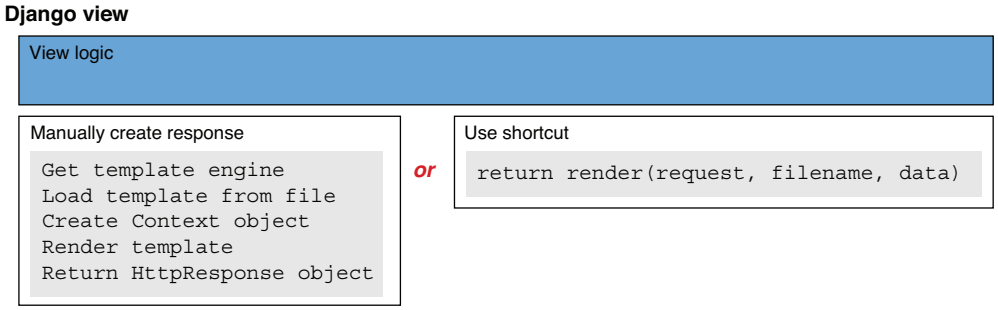


Figure 3.2 The `render()` shortcut saves you code

The `render()` function has two required arguments: the `HttpRequest` object passed into the view and the name of a template to load from disk. You tell Django where to look for templates by changing configuration in settings.py—more on that in a moment. The `render()` function also has optional arguments for providing a context dictionary, specifying the MIME type of the response and changing the HTTP status code.

The view for your Credits page consisted of a hardcoded string using plain text. You want RiffMates to contain more complicated pages than that. Let's add a view that shows your users the latest happenings on the site with a News page, this time using HTML.

You'll need a view for your News page. Call it `news()`, and put it in RiffMates/home/views.py along with your views for the Credits and About pages (if you did the exercises at the end of chapter 2). The `news()` view uses the `render()` shortcut, which needs to be imported at the top of the file.

The signature for `news()` is the same as `credits()`, taking a `request` object as an argument. Inside the view, a dictionary holds a list containing the news shown on the page. This dictionary gets passed to `render()` as context for the template. The result from `render()` is an `HttpResponse` object, which the view then returns. The `render()` shortcut takes three arguments:

- The `request` object
- The name of an HTML page, news.html in this case
- A reference to the data dictionary to be used as the template context

Modify RiffMates/home/views.py, adding the import for `render()` and the new code for `news()`, as in the following listing.